future but not as a goal that could be realized in the foreseeable future. This was because the Arabs did not contemplate any kind of coexistence with the Jewish state but sought only to destroy it. This was the logic that guided the Arabs as they applied pressure to come up with a definition for the Palestinian refugee that was fundamentally different from the definition of any other refugee; they sought to preserve the status of the Palestinian refugees and not to solve their problem. They therefore stubbornly insisted that Israel accept the principle of the "right of return" totally—by which all those who were defined as refugees, without exception, could return to their places of residence. This is a principle that is not applied to any other refugee, in any place or in any war. This demand was also formulated in "all or nothing" terms—that is, there was a refusal to enter negotiations on the number of refugees who would be allowed to return, the criteria of those who would be allowed to return, timetables, and so on.

This rigid stance, as detailed below, was convenient for Israel, which demanded recognition of the link between peace negotiations and the solution of the refugee problem. As long as the Arabs stood their ground on the "all or nothing" principle, Israel could avoid dealing with the refugee problem relatively easily. There was a body that would finance the refugees' basic needs without any of the financial burden falling on Israel (which was then poor and struggling to pay for the absorption of penniless immigrants whose number far surpassed that of the local population, a challenge that no country has ever met). Moreover, following the collapse of the Lausanne Conference (discussed below), there was no international pressure on Israel to participate in solving the problem. The refugees became an eternal quandary.

The UNRWA decided, for obvious reasons, to give Palestinian refugees a unique definition. UNRWA voluntarily took upon itself the eternal responsibility to sustain this one group of refugees in the world who did not meet the territorial conditions of refugee status, since they were not citizens of a state but subjects of the British Mandate. UN officials debated and likely argued over the definition of Palestinian refugeehood and came up with a wily definition that I, for one, am not at all certain stands any legal or moral test.

The agency determined that Palestinian refugees would be defined as *"persons whose normal place of residence* [interesting definition! Why not use the term *permanent residence?*] *was Palestine during the period 1 June*